

SUBJECTS

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Book Party

SEBASTIAN SCHMIDT and Raphael Sagalyn do essentially the same thing: sell books. Schmidt is a sculptor. His weightiest tomo, at 265 pounds, is of greenish marble, the lightest, weighing about a pound, of ruddy sandstone. Sagalyn is an American agent who sells foreign rights to the books he represents. Both were doing what they do every year at the Frankfurt Book Fair, the international publishing world's weeklong marathon of deals, near deals and parrying. Schmidt stood under a tent selling hefty volumes carved into sandstone, granite and travertine. Sagalyn was looking cramped at Table 257 in a riotously noisy hall with hundreds of other agents and editors.

This year's fair, held in mid-October, drew 6,887 exhibitors from 107 countries, including 842 publishers from the United States. To increase efficiency, Sagalyn at times adopts assembly-line methods. By 11 in the morning, he had met with a gaggle of Japanese publishers, the head of Penguin Books in London, an Argentine editor and Alan Wherry, the chief executive of Bloomsbury in the United States.

At his meeting with the Japanese, eight publishing executives, plus an interpreter, sat crowded around his laid table, rapidly scanning the rights lists and capsule summaries, taring a hand when they wanted to see more. The Japanese are into self-help, so they liked the forthcoming "Power Talk," by Sarah Myers McGinty, about using language to achieve authority, and they also went for "The Future of Success," by Robert Reich (due out in January). Had they read the books? "Reading? We're reading paragraphs. This is the quest for the big book," Sagalyn said.

Across the aisle, another agent was equally frenzied. Nicholas Ellison's day had begun with breakfast at his hotel with David Young, the president of Little, Brown in Britain, which publishes Ellison's best-selling client, Nelson DeMille. "We got to have a cup of coffee and break bread," Ellison said with a touch of understatement. He had met with prospective buyers every half-hour since to hawk foreign rights to a line-up that included "Up Country," DeMille's sequel to "The General's Daughter," and "Misfortune," a first novel by Nancy Geary, a lawyer turned writer. "Misfortune," which sold last year to Warner Books for \$600,000, had already been picked up by a German publisher for \$210,000. Ellison hoped he might repeat Geary's success with another first novel, "Equivocal Death," by Amy Gutman, who also used to be a lawyer.

Except for Schmidt the sculptor, and a row of booths selling book-related trinkets, the fair consists overwhelmingly of publishers seeking to sell foreign rights. At the Bloomsbury booth, the British publisher of the "Harry Potter" series, the director, Kathy Rooney, answered with playful crossness when asked about Harry's sales. "We all admire Harry Potter," she said, "but we are publishing 250 books a year." Jonathan Glasspool, director of the reference division, said that Harry's agent was out on the floor selling the foreign rights. "It's suddenly transformed his life," Glasspool said. "He's talking to someone now about Lithuania."



publisher, and Gore Vidal had lunch with his German publisher, Karl Blessing, to whom he boasted that, at 75, he was in "the springtime of my senility." But many publishers and agents, engrossed in their selling, were hardly aware that Czeslaw Milosz and Wislawa Szymborska, Nobel Prize-winning poets from Poland (which had a special exhibit at this year's fair), read their work at the opening ceremony. Gao Xingjian, the Chinese novelist and playwright who won this year's Nobel, held a news conference that illustrated the fair's Tower-of-Babel quality. The writer, who wore a black turtleneck and black suit and appeared slightly intimidated by the two husky bodyguards who accompanied him every step, spoke French, and was asked in German by a reporter, who used the Chinese word, to comment on the Chinese concept of "limitation." But Gao had to pass, puzzled equally by the German reporter's Chinese and an interpreter's French.

The work may be exhausting, but the editors, agents and publishers who come to Frankfurt still find the energy for successive waves of luncheons, dinners and receptions to exchange gossip and strike deals, ending up after midnight in the lobby of the Frankfurter Hof hotel. The hotel, once Hitler's favorite, was exorcised by Helen Wolff, the distinguished American editor and one of the fair's legends until her death in 1994. She never worked the floor but checked into Room 300-A, where she received editors, translators, agents and the writers she published: Italo Calvino, Stanislaw Lem, Amos Oz.

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